

PHIL1001: Ethics for the Digital Age



Week 03, Lect.B Troubles for Moral Relativism

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Agenda

1. Quick Recap of CR
2. CR and tolerance.
3. An "internal" objection to CR.
4. An objection from "intuitive" appeal: the reformer.
5. Another objection from intuitive appeal: progress.
6. The Argument from Disagreement Revisited.

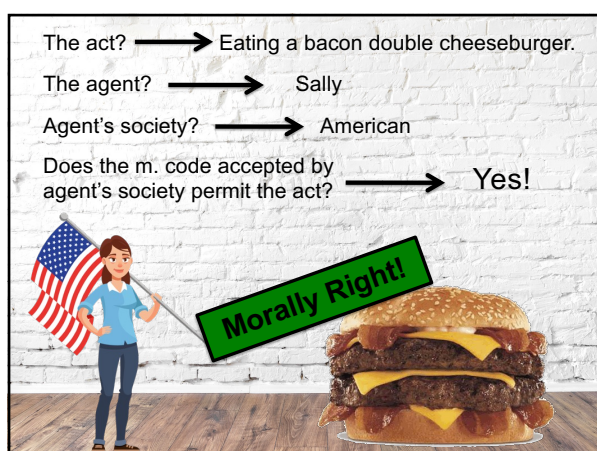
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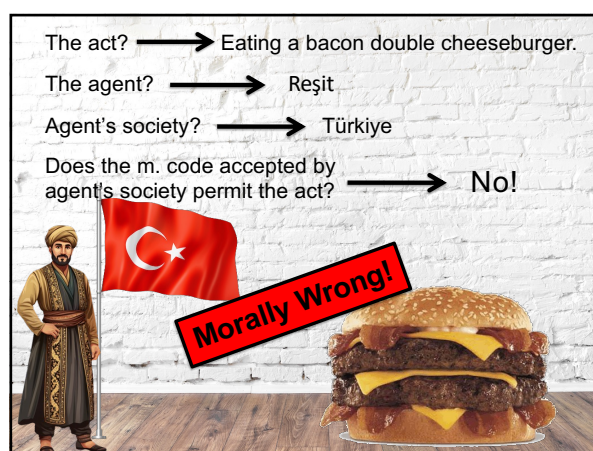
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CR: an act-token, x, is morally right if and only if
x is permitted the moral code that is accepted
by the society to which the agent of x belongs.

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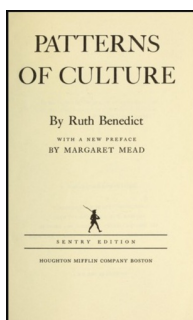


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What Does CR Imply About Toleration?

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Ruth Benedict (1934)



Ruth Benedict (1934/1960), *Patterns of Culture*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, p.278

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"The recognition of **cultural relativity** carries with it **its own values**, which need not be those of absolutist philosophies. [...]"

"We shall arrive then at a more realistic social faith, accepting as grounds of hope and as **a new basis for tolerance** the co-existing and equally valid patterns of life which mankind has created for itself from the raw materials of existence."



Ruth Benedict (1934/1960), *Patterns of Culture*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, p.278

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Q1: What does it mean to "tolerate" the behaviour of others?

Q2: Is Benedict correct in claiming that moral relativism (e.g. CR) implies that **people ought to tolerate "different" behaviour** by members of outside groups?

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The agent? → Tomás de Torquemada (1420-1498)
 Agent's society? → 15th Century Spain.
 The act? → Forcing someone to convert to Christianity.
 Does the m. code accepted by agent's society permit the act? → Yes



<< In case you are reading this without context: the idea is that **if CR were true***, then we would have to say that people living in 15th century Spain were doing no wrong when they forced non-Christians to convert, since such actions were permitted by the moral code of that society. >>

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Reminder: "Internal support" for/against a theory

"...if the principles of a theory have implications **that conflict** with our considered moral beliefs, this is **evidence against** the correctness of the theory."

Timmons (2002: 15).

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For Contrast: cases that favor relativism.

When the moral code of an agent's society differs from "our" moral code with respect to things like:

- (a) Assigning responsibility for the care of children,
- (b) Marriage between relatives (e.g. cousins),
- (c) (Im)modesty of dress,
- (d) Diet.

It can seem off to morally criticize the moral codes of other societies over differences like these.

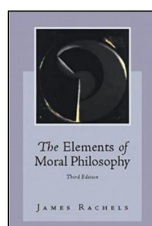
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**An Objection:
Moral Codes that
Permit Coercive
Harming of Innocents**

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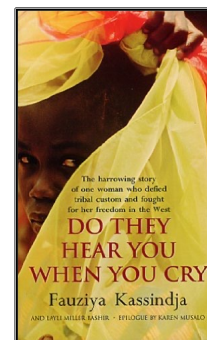
James Rachels

"The Challenge of Cultural Relativism".
In *The Elements of Moral Philosophy* 3rd Edition. Boston: McGraw Hill.



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Fauziya Kassindja



Source: http://cgrs.uchastings.edu/_images/fauziya_event.jpg

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The practice of clitoridectomy a.k.a. female genital mutilation

For information about the practice of clitoridectomy/FGM, and about the case of Fauziya Kassindja in particular, see:

Martha Nussbaum (1999). "Judging Other Cultures".
In *Sex and Social Justice*. New York: Oxford University Press.

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Kassindja's story described in Rachels's "The Challenge of Cultural Relativism" p. 31

"Fauziya Kassindja was the youngest of five daughters in a devoutly Muslim family. Her father...was opposed to excision, and he was able to defy the tradition because of his wealth...

But when Fauziya was 16, he suddenly died. [She] then came under the authority of [her grandfather], who arranged a marriage for her and prepared to have her excised.

Fauziya was terrified, and her mother and older sister helped her to escape."

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The argument from practices involving coercive harm:

P1. If CR is true, **then** it was morally wrong of Kassindja to refuse a clitoridectomy.

P2. It was **not** morally wrong of Kassindja to refuse a clitoridectomy.

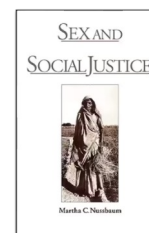
C. Therefore, CR is **not** true.

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For an attempt to respond to the concern that it is wrong (or hypocritical) to criticise another culture's practices see:

Martha Nussbaum (1999). "Judging Other Cultures: The Case of Female Genital Mutilation".

In *Sex and Social Justice*. Oxford University Press. (On LMS)



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Reminder: Evaluating a theory for **intuitive appeal**.

"A moral theory should develop and make sense of various intuitively appealing beliefs about morality."

Timmons (2002: 14).

e.g. (i). "Morality concerns the **well-being** of individuals."

e.g. (ii) "Morality is rooted in **human nature**."

e.g. (iii) "Morality represents an **impartial standpoint** for evaluating actions, people, and institutions."

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Another intuitively appealing belief
about morality:

Not every **moral reformer** in
history has been mistaken.

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Q: Who or what is a “moral reformer”?

A **moral reformer** is someone who
disagrees with some aspect of their own
society's moral code.

E.g. There exists some kind of action that is
permitted by their society's moral code,
but which they believe is really morally wrong.

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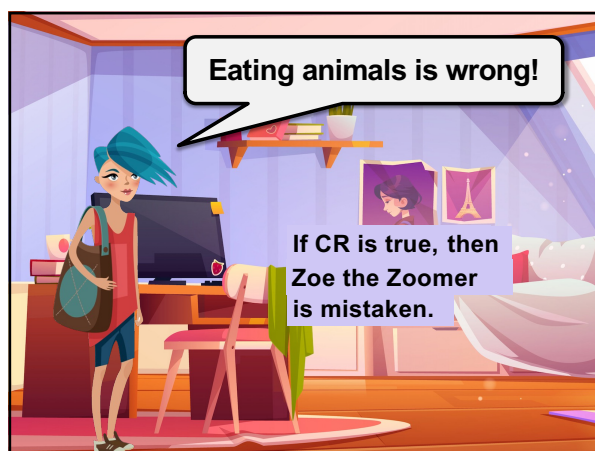
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The Argument from Moral Reformers:

P1. If CR is true, then every moral reformer is mistaken.

P2. It is not the case that every moral reformer is mistaken.

C. CR is not true.

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Most of you probably agree with the following:

There has been
moral progress
over time.

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Bodily Torture no longer a permitted form of punishment:



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Slavery now forbidden by our moral code:

Progress!

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A greater degree of **legal equality** with respect to sex and race:

Progress!

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Same sex marriage now recognised:

Progress!

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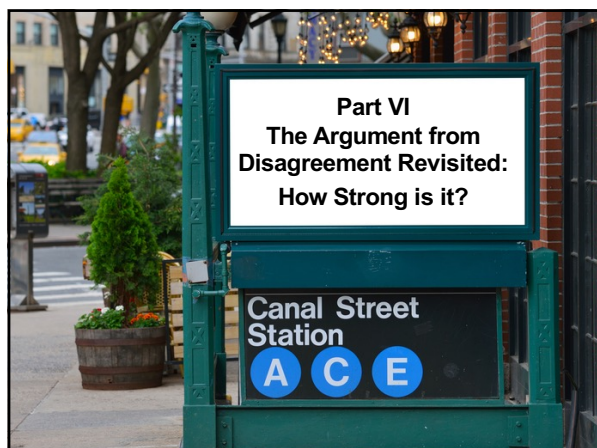
The Argument from moral progress:

P1. It makes sense to say that there has been some **moral progress**.

P2. If CR is true, then it does not make sense to say that there has been some moral progress.

C. CR is not true.

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The argument from disagreement, Version 2.0.

P1. Members of different cultures accept different moral codes.

P2'. If members of different cultures accept different moral codes, then this fact is **best explained** by the fact that no single moral code is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents.

C'. (Probably) there is no single moral code that is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents.

Compare with Wong (1991: 445-447) & Harman (1996: 8-14)

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Objection to P2:

Can Moral Disagreement Be Explained Equally Well by Absolutist-Friendly Hypotheses?

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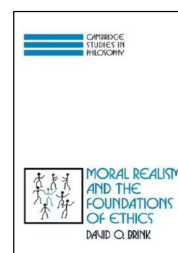
Some suggestions found in:

Brink, David O. (1989) *Moral Realism and the Foundations of Ethics*. Cambridge University Press.

See pp. 197-209



David Brink



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Even if *there is* a single true moral code, it is *not surprising* that there is persistent moral disagreement.

The disagreement may be caused by:

- (a) Differences in **non-moral** beliefs.
- (b) Differences in **circumstances**.
- (c) **Bias** from self-interest.

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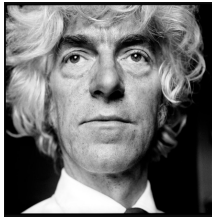
Objection to P1:

Do relativists Overstate
The Extent of *Fundamental* Moral
Disagreement Among Cultures?

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A collection of passages compiled in

Derek Parfit (2011), *On What Matters*, Vol.1.
New York: Oxford University Press, pp. 460-470.



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Christianity: "Whatever you would will that men do to you, do you to them" (Matthew 7:12).

Islam: "None of you is a believer until he wants for his brother that which he wants for himself" (Sunnah).

Judaism: "What is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow man. This is the entire Law; all the rest is commentary" (Talmud)

Hinduism: "This is the sum of duty; Do nothing to others that you would not have them do to you" (Mahabharata 5:1517.)

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Buddhism: "Hurt not others in ways that you yourself would find hurtful" (Udana-Varga 5:18).

Confucianism: "Do not do to others what you do not want them to do to you" (Analects 15:23).

Taoism: "Regard your neighbor's gain as your gain, and your neighbor's loss as your own loss" (Tai Shang Kan Yin P'ien).

Shinto: "The heart of the person before you is a mirror. See there your own form" (Munetada Kurozumi).

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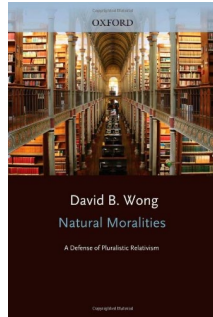
Part VII Postscript

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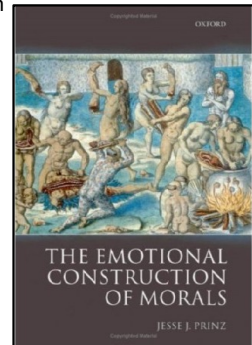
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David Wong, (2006) *Natural Moralities* (Oxford UP)



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Jesse Prinz (2007),
The Emotional Construction
of Morals (Oxford UP)



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